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Dear Jamie Brown, Matt Davidson, Wayne Ermel, Steve Berry, Bill Farr, Pat O'Donnell (MEEA), and Paul Robinson,

Just a note on the events that led up to me very sadly and unexpectedly leaving The Age on 31/05/04.

It all seemed to start when I took a sick day off on 29th of May. And indeed, I was sincerely ill. I did not sleep the whole night for throwing up, and henceforth called Matt at 9am, to give him fair warning when I knew I was not definitely coming in. Upon no answer, I left a message on his home phone. I followed up with a call at 11am, and managed to contact him then.

Jamie asked me about this absence and I explained. He was not impressed, and seemed not to believe me.

In the afternoon, I saw Jamie and Luisa in the cafeteria talking. It was clear from the impression I got it was a private conversation. I left them alone.

I heard Luisa say later that afternoon, 'No problems with the roster?', quite tersely. I wondered what that was about at the time, I thought to myself, 'Nope, no problems here'. I have always made allowances constantly for changes in roster.

It was only when I looked at the roster that I saw what she was referring to-every casual was rostered on nearly full shifts, while my roster showed a TWO and A HALF week absence. This had not happened in three and a half years. I felt it was surely unfair. Jamie had explained to me, that the casual rosters were more or less split up between the three of us when full timers are on leave or holidays. This had always been the case. And in regards for myself, had up until that point been done so fairly.

It had not been so fair for others such as Simon Sheldon. And although I do not know the circumstances regarding his position, I was aware he was a good worker, and was complaining of low shifts.

Luisa informs me she split the roster up accordingly with Simon, and got feedback from Jamie, saying, 'No, put him on a half shift a week'. Henceforth I don't envy a position such as Jamies that, while having to look after the company and get the best out of workers, which is clearly his job, has to compromise friendship over work. It astounds me the way management can play with peoples lives like that. It is why I was, and probably always will be a worker, and not in a management position.

Pending seeing what the roster was, considering my financial situation, rent, car loan, computer loan, bills, ie: I have to live, and studying on top of that, I decided to confront Jamie on why the shifts were as they were, and should I ask him, or Luisa about it, who had written the roster.

"That's just the way the roster fell". Was his immediate answer, and as far as I could tell, he

did not want to discuss it any further.

Upon a confrontation about this roster he added, "Well you haven't been the most reliable worker". Enter the new equation. Jamie and Luisa have altered the roster to teach a very ill Richard that he is not to stuff around with having days off. It may have just been that Jamie was looking after the best interests of the department and the company. It seemed however, like a vindictive way of 'Teaching him a lesson'.

A more appropriate way of dealing with it would be to confront me about these shifts, maybe ask for a certificate, talk about the options the company was going to employ to address the situation. No such luck. Casuals always just seem to die a slow death in the art department.

Let me just say that times are tough, and I needed the money. If I could have worked, I surely would have. I can provide a doctors certificate if need be.

Let me also say that Saturdays are yes, a busy day, and probably one of the reasons why, as Jo put it, 'It was pretty busy', was that yes, I did pull my weight in the department. I knew that for a fact. You get sorely missed when you are a good worker and have the day off. An old Chinese proverb says: "Don't make yourself irreplaceable-you will never get promoted". Luisa also informs me the graphics tracker is monitored and graphed for the amount of jobs you do. Lets see those graphs.

When I do work Saturdays, as always, I work hard, and I do apologise to my fellow workers for leaving them short. However, I had made myself available and shown up the vast majority of the time for three and a half years. And if I don't work, I don't get paid. Surely as a casual we do have some type of leg to stand on when it comes to issues such as this. Apparently not. Maybe I should have come in and vomited on the desk, that used to be mine but I was asked to move all my files and belongings off it for a full timer, no disrespect to full timers.

So I had two options- one was to grin and bear it, come in when I am asked and serve a slow death in the department, as we have witnessed with other workers. Frankly, management had me by the balls. Or to have let my emotions take hold and quit. So I did. Emotions can't be wrong, and it was a heated conflict, but I have my pride.

I have given three and a half years to that art department, and was active in every conceivable job from news graphic, illustration, even court drawing. I was clearly respected for my talent in the team and the department used this to its advantage, as it should.

I had approached management on more than one occasion about full time work. I had ambitions of spending a long time in the company, and just wanted some security-some appreciation of what I had given thus far. On the last occasion I asked to speak to Steve, I was denied that meeting.

Henceforth it is with great sadness that I leave The Age.

I apologise if this letter is offensive to anyone, but quite frankly, this is the honest

truth on how I see it. I needed to say my piece. I am not about to be walked over.

On a more positive note, I have enjoyed the time I have spent at the AGE. It was my dream job. I remember going to uni and looking for the 'Matt Davidson's', and the 'Lisa Nolan's', and, the 'Jamie Brown's' in the age and herald sun, and the leunig's, knights and tandberg's amongst others. I am happy for the experience it has given me in design and illustration, and the wonderful people I have met in my experience there. I feel complimented in the company I kept while working there.

Jamie-I still have the greatest respect for your talents. And thank you for the support and good feedback on illos and jobs you have given me over the time. However I do feel hard done by and have needed to say my piece. I hope you can understand that. I wish you all the best at the age for years to come.

Matt-Hope you end up running the show!

Waynus-Good luck me little mate.

Steve and Bill- I forwarded this letter to you both because I felt I needed to tell the big guns what the lackey went through. Maybe it can be avoided with other lackeys.

MEEA: FYI. Casuals need to be heard.

Under the circumstances, I would appreciate it if you sent me an employment seperation certificate so I can continue to search for work elsewhere.

A final word- I think I was, and well could have been a great asset to the company. And I say that honestly and without putting myself on a pedestal. Looks like the age missed that one.

I remain yours truthfully, and sincerely,

Richard McLean.